Silent. Not a word. A Congress spokesperson gave out just a by-the-way statement excusing Mr Gandhi's couple of missed days during the parliament session as a consequence of taking the jab.

India was not going to shy away from supplying cost-effective vaccines to the rest of the world, primarily to developing and underdeveloped nations. In the third week of September, the Union health minister announced that India was set to produce over 300 million doses by October. Since our security was ensured, we'd resume our Vaccine Maitri programme. The announcement was reiterated by the prime minister on his bilateral visit to the US for the Quad Summit, during his address to the 76th United Nations General Assembly and his remarks at the Global COVID-19 Summit later in the month.

The Indian economy markers were gaining solid footing showing that the economy was rapidly recovering from the COVID-19 impact, poised to grow at the world's fastest rate. The fact that we didn't lock down the country at the same time during the second wave, with states instituting lockdown measures only when required for very brief periods of time ensured that although economic recovery momentum had suffered, greater activity across sectors limited the economic damage. Experts believe that the rate of vaccinations picking up, rapid resumption in manufacturing activity and a milder hit on the services sector were some of the reasons that kept the economy afloat during the second wave. The RBI's low-interest regime and the GoI's bet on infrastructure investments had also helped to minimize the damage. In other words, the second wave did impact India's economy but many times lesser than the first wave.

India recorded a 20.1 per cent growth in GDP for the April–June 2021 quarter, bringing it on par with pre-pandemic levels and reaffirming its imminent V-shaped recovery forecast. For August 2021, ₹1,12,020 crore of gross GST revenue was collected, which was 30 per cent higher than GST revenues of the same month last year and 19 per cent higher than those collected in the same month in FY 2019–20.

These encouraging growth numbers reaffirmed the sound economic policies which India adopted from the start of the pandemic. Ruchir Sharma, Morgan Stanley Investment Management's chief global strategist, wrote in the *Financial Times* that, 'Emerging economies that stimulated most aggressively (inspired by the US and other large developed countries "go-big" on economic stimulus) got no pay-off in a faster recovery. In fact,